

Thanks, but no thanks

According to a study, 49 per cent of gamers won't buy downloadable content
<http://goo.gl/Ecg9u>

A new beginning

EA's online distribution platform, Origin, recently crossed the five million daily users milestone
<http://goo.gl/6xQP8>

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It just seems silly, in this day and age, for games to still be sold in tiny breakable plastic discs. Let's say you're sold on the idea of buying digital games online. What next?

We take a look at Steam, GamersGate, Good Old Games, Impulse, Beamdog and Green Man Gaming, helping you get your gaming high online.

Steam

Created by Valve, and used in all Valve games since *Half-Life 2*, Steam is possibly the most popular, influential and well stocked of all digital game distribution services. Steam is more than just that, it's also a DRM platform.



Steam links your games to your account, allowing you to download and play them from any computer that has Steam installed, as long you log into your Steam account. In addition, there are community features such as achievements, game and game-item trading, leaderboards, chatting etc. Steam offers games for both Mac OS X and Windows, and with SteamPlay, you can purchase once and play on both platforms.

Steam has the widest collection of games and routinely has sales that often have games at very low prices, at times lower than what it would cost to pirate.

Pros:

- Widest collection, for both Mac and Windows
- Frequent sales; daily deals
- Community features
- Games can be played directly after download, no set-up required
- Also has Free To Play games

Cons:

- Requires the client to play a game

ONLINE GAME DOWNLOAD SERVICES & STORES

- Steam doesn't let you play a game if a newer patched version is available
- Have to install everything under the Steam folder

GamersGate

Started by Paradox Interactive, a Swedish game development company. It has a huge game collection, rivalled only by Steam.

GamersGate provides you with an individual downloader for each game that downloads and installs the game. It enforces no DRM on its own, however, you need to log into the downloader before you can use it.

GamersGate has an interesting system called "Blue Coins" which rewards people for participating in the community (posting reviews, walkthroughs, guides etc.) and for purchasing games. These Blue Coins can also be purchased directly or gifted and can in turn be used to purchase more games. GamersGate allows you to purchase multiple copies of a game which can then be gifted. Like Steam, GamersGate includes games for both Windows and Mac OS X operating systems. Often purchasing a game means you get access to both versions, but not necessarily.



Pros:

- No enforced client
- Frequent sales
- Rewards for purchases, reviews etc.
- Large collection of games
- Games for Windows and Mac OS X

- Includes one free game for all

Cons:

- Forced downloader; no direct downloads

Impulse

Impulse is an online game and software store started by Stardock. It was recently purchased by GameStop.

It offers prices in INR, which are merely a conversion from their USD prices. The pricing itself is not sensitive to the Indian market. It has a decent collection of games, but only few are available to Indian customers.



Impulse doesn't offer as many community features as Steam, but then again, it isn't as intrusive either. Games downloaded from Impulse run without Internet. Though, games may include their own DRM which could make an Internet connection necessary.

Pros:

- Prices in INR
- Don't need the client running to play games
- Daily deals, and regular sales

Cons:

- Many games are not available for India
- Need a client to download the games

Desura

Desura is a game distribution service that is quite focused on the community aspects of gaming. It's more inclusive than Steam in some aspects like game development, modding and players community. It has a strong focus on modding.

The Desura client can even manage games that you download and install from other sources. You can download and install mods directly from its client. It offers and supports mods for third party games such as *Half-Life*.

It even offers numerous free and open-source games and in general the